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EMERGING TECH RESEARCH

Paris Blockchain Week

Profiling the top 12 startups from the event’s Start in Block competition

PitchBook is a Morningstar company providing the most comprehensive, most accurate, and hard-to-find data for professionals doing business in the private markets.

Introduction

Paris Blockchain Week this year was held on April 8-10, 2025, for its sixth edition, setting new records with more than 10,000 attendees, 420 speakers, and delegates from more than 85 countries. The mood on the ground remained constructive despite a choppy first quarter for the crypto markets. The global crypto market cap hovered near \$2.8 trillion, up roughly 13% YoY, underscoring investors’ longer-term confidence in the asset class. Conference programming drilled into the EU’s Markets in Crypto-Assets Regulation (MiCA) implementation, institutional on-ramps, AI-agent infrastructure, and the next evolution of decentralized finance (DeFi).

PitchBook again this year took an active role in the Investors & Founders Day, helping screen hundreds of startups, selecting the top 12 startups for the pitch session, and joining the panel “Deploying Smart Money: LP Strategies and VC Tactics for Sustainable Returns in Crypto.” Discussions centered on the shifting mix of LPs into crypto VC funds, investable areas for VCs, and what the future could hold for startups as the liquidity cycles begin to normalize.

The day-long program doubled as a matchmaking hub for founders, VC firms, decentralized autonomous organization (DAO) treasuries, and strategic corporates. Its centerpiece—the [Start in Block competition](#)—drew more than 1,000 startup submissions; a jury of 400-plus investors shortlisted 12 finalists who pitched live for a prize pool of more than \$10 million in funding, grants, and service credits. We had the opportunity to meet the final 12 startups—including the three winners, Almanx, EarnOS, and Glider—which included companies developing within the DeFi, AI, and consumer categories.

 Almanax

Founded: 2024

Headquartered: New York, NY

Startup profiles

Almanax

Overview

Almanax, one of the three Start in Block competition winners, sets out to become the AI “security engineer” that Web3 sorely lacks. The team’s thesis is that nearly \$9 billion has been stolen from crypto projects in just three years, and the attack surface is expanding faster than human auditors or rule-based scanners can cope. Almanax applies large language model (LLM) agents to reason across entire codebases—smart contracts, traditional back-end services, and even software supply chain dependencies—and flags exploitable logic with far fewer false positives than legacy static analysis tools. In parallel, the company is spearheading an open-source Web3 Security Atlas, a domain-specific equivalent of ImageNet that supplies the curated data needed to keep those models well-tuned.

Product and technology

Almanax’s flagship offering is an AI-powered scanning platform that plugs into common CI/CD pipelines via a lightweight “Almanax Runner.” The runner packages source code and dependencies inside the customer’s virtual private cloud, sending only vectorized embeddings to the cloud, where the ALMX 1.5 model family performs long-context reasoning. That architecture satisfies enterprise compliance requirements—no customer code leaves the perimeter—yet still benefits from centrally updated weights.

ALMX 1.5 is a multilingual, fine-tuned LLM that outperforms both Slither (static analysis) and GPT 4-based prompts on benchmark suites derived from real-world exploits, especially in business logic and cross-file vulnerabilities. In head-to-head tests on Code4rena repositories, ALMX caught high-severity randomness and signature malleability flaws that Slither missed, while reducing noise by hiding low certainty findings by default.

The open-source Web3 Security Atlas underpins this performance: It aggregates production repositories, historical audit reports, and exploit transcripts across Ethereum Virtual Machine (EVM) and Solana today, with Stellar Soroban and Move-based chains on the 2025 roadmap. By controlling both model training and benchmark data, Almanax can iterate quickly and publish transparent performance metrics—an approach reminiscent of Google’s JFT 300M loop.

Beyond smart contracts, the platform already performs one-click software bill of materials scans to catch dependency-level malware and typosquatting attacks, reflecting Almanax’s belief that “bridge” and supply chain compromises will dominate the next wave of Web3 losses. Support currently spans Solidity, Rust, Go, and Move, and the company’s REST API lets customers funnel alerts from third-party tools (Snyk, Socket) into Almanax’s ranking engine to further suppress false positives.

Technically, the system is centralized at inference time (weights remain proprietary), but the Atlas dataset and evaluation harness are MIT-licensed, striking a pragmatic hybrid between open collaboration and defensible enterprise IP.

Team

Co-founder & CEO Francesco Piccoli previously ran product at AnChain.AI, where he built blockchain forensics tools used by the US Securities and Exchange Commission and Internal Revenue Service and led investigations into nine-figure exploits. He holds an MA in English from UC Berkeley and has prior research credits in anomaly detection at Ripple and autonomous vehicle perception at Volvo. Co-founder and CTO Maxwell Watson spent five years at Coinbase, most recently on staking infrastructure, and earlier helped build Capsule8's kernel security platform (acquired by Sophos). They are joined by founding ML engineer Giorgio Demarchi (MIT, Amazon Robotics), software engineer Steven Benmoha (Mastercard Crypto), and security specialists John Lawniczak (Fireblocks) and Pranjali Thakur (Circle).

Funding

In January 2025 Almanax closed a \$1.5 million seed round led by Defy Partners, with participation from Gemini's Frontier Fund, Exor Seeds, Moonbase Capital, Vento, Blockchain Builders Fund, Eden Ventures, Italian Angels for Growth, and angels including Bartek Ringwelski (previously at Coinbase COO) and Nafis Jamal (previously at Stripe). Proceeds are earmarked for expanding the research & engineering team and broadening Atlas coverage to additional chains and maximal extractable value/bridge attack surfaces.

Our view

Almanax's blend of proprietary LLMs and an open, community-maintained dataset carves out a strategic moat: Atlas crowdsourcing builds mind share while closed weight models retain enterprise margins. The biggest execution risks are staying ahead of frontier model context windows from OpenAI and Anthropic and defending territory if GitHub Advanced Security or Coinbase integrates similar AI detectors upstream. Still, early wins with security auditors and wallet providers—and the ability to surface critical bugs in seconds—suggest real signal. Should the company maintain its technical lead, it could emerge as the "Datadog of on-chain security," and we believe its domain-specific dataset and models could make it a logical acquisition target for Coinbase or a cloud security giant seeking Web3 exposure.



Founded: 2024

Headquartered: Manchester, UK

Amplifi

Overview

Amplifi is building an AI layer that sits above existing liquidity protocols and automates yield generation for bitcoin and stablecoin holders. The platform's motto of "deposit once, earn everywhere" aims to address two persistent hurdles to broader DeFi adoption: the technical friction of juggling wallets, gas fees, and bridges, and the cognitive load of monitoring dozens of pools whose returns decay quickly. By packaging sophisticated cross-chain strategies behind a single on-chain vault interface, Amplifi aims to give retail and enterprise users the transparency of DeFi with a user experience closer to a traditional robo-advisor.

Product and technology

Amplifi offers one-click vaults for bitcoin and dollar-pegged assets. A proprietary AI & ML engine allocates deposits across liquidity pools on multiple chains, continually rebalancing as yields, volatility, and on-chain risk indicators change. The same engine drives an automated risk-management layer that watches for abnormal pool metrics and can migrate funds when conditions deteriorate. Cross-chain execution is handled through Polyhedra's zkBridge, so users avoid manual bridging and the associated security pitfalls. To lower the barrier further, Amplifi employs account abstraction: Transactions are gas-sponsored, and wallets can be created with a social-login flow.

Architecturally, the protocol is hybrid-decentralized and the smart contracts that custody assets are open-source, while the strategy-selection code and ML models remain closed. This split lets the team iterate on proprietary algorithms without compromising the verifiability of user funds. Interoperability is core to the roadmap: Today, the system operates on Ethereum Virtual Machine (EVM) chains, but support for Solana (Solana Virtual Machine) and the emerging BitVM ecosystem is scheduled, reflecting the goal of acting as a universal yield router rather than a chain-specific vault.

Team

Founder Jeff Cafolla previously worked in crypto venture and growth roles before starting Amplifi and was also previously at Meta; his public commentary focuses on reducing DeFi's learning curve for the next hundred million users. He is joined by Jake White (CTO, 14 years in software with five leading Web3 product teams), Vish H (COO, 12 years at Accenture, PwC, JPMorgan Chase, and other large banks), Jonny Quirke (Community), Wayne Sim (Marketing), Kody King (Experience) and Rafe (head of AI). The mix of ML, user experience (UX), and community specialists aligns with Amplifi's ambition to hide algorithmic complexity behind an approachable interface.

Funding

Amplifi is in the process of raising a \$2 million seed round, with about \$400,000 raised so far. The fresh capital is earmarked for expanding to all major DeFi

chains, extending vault coverage beyond stablecoins into ETH-based strategies, and completing security audits ahead of a planned token-generation event later this year.

Our view

AI-driven yield routers have become a crowded theme, but Amplifi's combination of account abstraction, zk-based bridging, and focus on Bitcoin—an asset class that many DeFi aggregators still ignore—gives it a differentiated starting point. The hybrid architecture is sensible: Keeping vault logic on-chain satisfies transparency requirements, while private ML models preserve an information edge. The main execution risks we see are sustaining model performance as Level 1 (L1)/Level 2 (L2) continue to proliferate and defending margin when larger aggregators integrate similar AI features. If the team can prove that its automated reallocations outperform static vaults net of fees, Amplifi could capture the segment of users who want DeFi yields without DeFi overhead.

Bloom

Overview

Bloom is evolving from its roots as a desktop wallet into a social discovery hub that turns on-chain activity into shareable, one-click trading content. The product surfaces live, actionable ideas—swaps, mints, bridge moves, Polymarket bets—drawn from the wallets and social handles a user follows across Farcaster, Lens, and X (formerly Twitter)-native transaction posters. The core problem Bloom addresses is the gap between social discussion and demonstrable execution: Telegram threads and tweets offer opinions, but there is no proof that a trade was actually placed or that a token was minted. By mapping verified wallet actions to social identities, Bloom supplies that proof and lets followers mirror the transaction directly from the feed. The team's thesis is that every on-chain interaction is a social signal, and packaging those signals as consumable content lowers both the research burden and the execution friction for the next wave of retail users.

Product and technology

The new Bloom application ingests real-time data from EVM blockchains, Farcaster frames, Lens posts, and Polymarket markets into an event pipeline that cleans, labels, and ranks items for relevance. A lightweight graph model scores each event against a user's social graph and portfolio to decide what appears in the personalized feed. One-click actions are enabled through deep links to the underlying protocols (for example, Uniswap swaps, Base mints, Polymarket order tickets).

Identity and compliance sit underneath the social layer. Bloom is part of an EU consortium with IOTA Foundation, IDnow, walt.id, and Spyce5 that is building a MiCA-compliant, zero-knowledge identity standard; a single know-your-customer event issues a portable ZK credential that can be presented when regulatory thresholds (for example, large swaps) are crossed.



Founded: 2023

Headquartered: London, UK

The public-facing smart-contract interactions remain decentralized and open-source, while the event-scoring and recommendation algorithms are proprietary. The desktop wallet that predates the pivot continues to serve as the execution layer; it currently counts about 15,000 monthly active users across IOTA, Shimmer, and EVM chains.

Team

Bloom was founded by Charlie Varley (CEO) and Nicole Kurt (CTO). Both previously spent several years at the IOTA Foundation, where Varley was director of engineering and Kurt was a technical lead on security-sensitive government projects. Their backgrounds combine L1 engineering, wallet UX, and formal security practices—skills that map directly onto Bloom’s emphasis on verifiable identity and safe transaction flows.

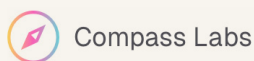
Funding

The company closed a \$1.5 million pre-seed round in December 2024 led by Lightspeed Faction. Strategic angels include Aave founder Stani Kulechov along with Delta Blockchain Fund, APX (Axel Springer × Porsche), CoinTelegraph, and Outlier Ventures. The capital is earmarked for expanding the event-ingestion stack beyond EVM to Solana and Stark-based chains and for formal audits of the upcoming ZK-credential module.

Our view

Social trading in the crypto space has been gaining momentum, but Bloom’s focus on verified execution and MiCA-ready identity gives it a compliance-first angle that many peers lack. The hybrid approach—open smart-contract interactions paired with proprietary ranking—offers room to monetize without locking user funds. We view some execution risks to include persuading power users to share trades in real time (the cold-start problem) and competing with protocol-native “share” buttons that may obviate the need for an aggregator. If Bloom can sustain a high signal-to-noise ratio while adding chains and maintaining privacy guarantees, it could capture the segment of users who want proof-based social signals rather than influencer commentary.

Compass Labs



Founded: 2022

Headquartered: London, UK

Overview

Compass Labs develops infrastructure that abstracts the technical complexity of on-chain finance so software teams and quantitative researchers can build DeFi applications without deep Solidity expertise. Its offering addresses three recurring pain points: fragmented data pipelines, difficulty testing strategies safely, and high integration costs each time a new protocol or chain is added. By combining a high-level execution application programming interface (API) with a Python-native simulation environment, Compass Labs lets users pull cleaned DeFi data, back-test strategies on local blockchain forks, and send intent-based transactions to

production—all without writing smart-contract code. The company's goal is to shorten a build-measure-deploy loop that currently spans weeks into hours and make DeFi functionality accessible to wallets, exchanges, algorithmic funds, and, increasingly, AI agents.

Product and technology

Compass offers two tightly linked products. Compass API connects more than 40 endpoints that cover swapping, lending, borrowing, staking, and liquidity provision across multiple EVM chains. Each call is intent-based: Developers describe the outcome (for example, an Aave leveraged position), and the backend compiles the required contract interactions. Keys remain client-side, so execution is noncustodial. Dojo is a Python-first research and simulation framework that supplies block-level data, agent-based simulations on local forks, and metric dashboards. Strategists can prototype algorithms against historical data, stress test them in forked environments, and move them to the mainnet by flipping a single flag. Recent integrations include Google Cloud's Analytics Hub, which lets institutions query Compass datasets directly from BigQuery, and ElizaOS, giving autonomous agents programmatic access to DeFi actions. Together, the stack positions Compass Labs as a bridge between conventional data-science tooling and live blockchain execution.

Key technical differentiators include agent-based simulations on user-controlled infrastructure, an intent compiler that collapses multistep transactions into one call, and cross-chain coverage delivered through a single interface. While the core API is proprietary, Dojo's examples and simulation tooling are open-source, encouraging community contributions and transparency.

Team

Compass Labs was founded by Elisabeth Duijnste, (CEO) and Lukas Scheucher (CTO). Duijnste holds a Ph.D. in physics from the University of Oxford and previously built quantitative strategies at a Dutch hedge fund; her research background informed the firm's focus on rigorous simulation. Scheucher, a former Google software engineer with a master's degree in high-performance computing from the Technical University of Munich, leads architecture and low-latency execution. The broader team includes engineers with experience in computational finance, machine learning, and blockchain indexers.

Funding

In March 2024, Compass Labs secured an undisclosed venture round from Canonical Crypto, Eterna Capital, and Oxford's Saïd Business School. Later that month, the company joined Andreessen Horowitz's Crypto Startup Accelerator (CSX) Spring 2024 cohort, receiving \$500,000 in program funding. Capital is being applied to expand protocol coverage beyond Aave, Uniswap, and GMX; harden the intent compiler for institutional volume; and certify data pipelines to meet bank-grade audit standards.

Our view

Compass sits at the intersection of data infrastructure and execution tooling, a segment that incumbents such as Alchemy and QuickNode only partially address. The combination of a noncustodial, intent-based API and a local simulation framework is appealing to systematic funds and to the growing class of AI-driven agents that need both data access and transaction rails. We believe the challenges for Compass revolve around latency and throughput—two metrics where centralized exchanges still hold an advantage—and the likelihood that larger node providers will roll out competing intent compilers. We believe the a16z support could help it reach the next milestones, and early traction with agent frameworks suggests Compass could become a default backend for AI-enabled DeFi apps. If it proves out the thesis that developers want “Stripe for on-chain finance,” Compass Labs could emerge as critical middleware in a multichain future or a strategic acquisition target for a data infrastructure giant seeking exposure to DeFi.



Founded: 2021

Headquartered: London, UK

EarnOS

Overview

EarnOS, another of the three Start in Block competition winners, is a consumer-engagement platform that enables brands to pay users directly—usually in stablecoins—when they watch a video, test a product, or share content. The product targets three shortcomings of Web2 ads: opaque audience data, delayed payment cycles, and minimal user control. EarnOS moves the value exchange on-chain, so every mission completion is recorded, instantly settled, and auditable. Users can sign in with email and claim rewards without handling wallets, while brands reach verified, real individuals rather than bots. The company positions itself as an operating system for “engage, verify, earn” and argues that paying users for their attention will outperform impression-based models as privacy rules tighten.

Product and technology

At the product’s core is a campaign builder that lets marketers configure tasks (follow, post, mint, attend an event), allocate a budget, and choose targeting rules. EarnOS’s matching layer relies on zkTLS, a zero-knowledge extension of Transport Layer Security (TLS) that proves a user meets audience criteria (location, device, past purchases) without revealing the raw data. Once a mission is completed, the smart contract releases a stablecoin payout—no points or lockups—and the action feeds into a leaderboard that drives repeat engagement. All activity settles on the XION blockchain, selected for low fees and built-in account abstraction; users can transact with just an email and one-time password, while power users can connect self-custody wallets. The roadmap adds self-service dashboards and deeper analytics so brands can A/B-test incentives and optimize cost per engaged user in real time.

EarnOS runs a hybrid architecture: Identity proofs and reward disbursements are on-chain and open-source, but the semantic-analysis engine that scores brand safety and audience relevance is proprietary. The company maintains chain agnosticism for rewards (USDC and other stablecoins) yet uses XION as the

settlement layer to abstract gas fees from end users. Instant payouts—advertised as “complete a mission, get paid in seconds”—make the service attractive for micro tasks that would not be economical on Layer 1 networks.

Team

EarnOS was founded by Philip George (CEO), Reece Johnson (technology executive officer), and Tom Riordan (head of product). George previously worked in brand partnerships at a global media agency; Johnson brings a decade of full-stack engineering and smart-contract experience; Riordan’s background spans product roles in consumer financial technology (fintech). The mix aligns with the platform’s intersection of advertising technology, blockchain infrastructure, and user-centric design.

Funding

In January 2025, EarnOS raised a \$5 million seed round led by Escape Velocity. Finality Capital Partners, Animoca Brands, GD1, and Laser Digital joined the deal. Proceeds will expand user acquisition, add self-service tools for smaller brands, and extend campaign formats beyond social media actions to in-store redemptions and on-chain loyalty programs.

Our view

Web3 reward platforms typically use the “faucet model,” where users try to gamify the system to earn free rewards. EarnOS’s use of zkTLS to prove audience attributes without sacrificing privacy sets a higher compliance bar than many other reward platforms, an advantage as Europe’s Digital Services Act and the American Data Privacy and Protection Act (ADPPA) push toward consent-based advertising. The hurdle will be scaling brand demand and avoiding reward farming; mechanisms such as dynamic cost-per-verified-user pricing and fraud detection are essential. If EarnOS can show lower acquisition costs and verifiable reach compared with Meta or Google, it could win budget from challenger brands and blockchain-native games. Partnering with big brands such as Uber, HSBC, and Lacoste is an early win for EarnOS.

GenieAI

Overview

GenieAI provides an AI-driven portfolio and risk-management platform designed for institutional investors in digital assets. Funds that trade across centralized exchanges, custodians, and on-chain venues often struggle to maintain a unified picture of positions, profit and loss, and factor exposures. GenieAI tackles that fragmentation by streaming data from each venue into a single cloud service, applying predictive and generative models to the feed, and delivering decision-ready analytics through a web console or API. The company’s stated aim is to reduce the time between data collection and portfolio action, enabling managers to react more quickly to volatility and automate routine reporting.



Founded: 202?

Headquartered: Boston, MA

Product and technology

GenieAI's stack is organized around four tightly integrated modules. Portfolio Intelligence ingests balances, trades, and historical fills from exchanges such as Binance, Coinbase Prime, OKX, and Deribit as well as from custodians such as Fireblocks and Copper, then produces real-time attribution of returns by asset, strategy, and venue. Risk Radar subjects those positions to thousands of simulated market scenarios and highlights liquidity or counterparty concentrations before they become binding constraints. A Multi-Strategy Optimizer uses ML models to recommend capital allocations that satisfy user-defined return targets and exposure limits; once a manager approves the proposal, trades can be routed directly through exchange APIs without passing through GenieAI custody. Strategy Lab offers a managed ML-Ops environment where researchers back-test hypotheses on cleaned historical data, schedule retraining jobs, and push models into production with minimal DevOps overhead. The architecture is centralized software as a service (SaaS)—market data sits in GenieAI's cloud while exchange keys remain client-side in secure enclaves—but code samples and back-testing notebooks are open-sourced to speed evaluation.

Team

GenieAI was founded by Federico Mele, who serves as CEO, and Lorenzo Gentile, who is CTO. Mele previously invested in fintech and data-infrastructure companies at a New York growth-equity fund; his background in evaluating institutional tools informs the firm's product focus. Gentile conducted doctoral research in mathematical optimization at Politecnico di Milano and later built large-scale ML pipelines as a software engineer at AppLovin. Together, they lead a distributed team of engineers and data scientists with experience in quantitative finance, exchange connectivity, and low-latency systems.

Funding

GenieAI closed a seed round of undisclosed size in March 2022 that included Coinbase Ventures, Bain Capital Ventures, and Venrex Investment Management; Astir Ventures, Goodwater Capital, Lumen Ventures, Sierra Ventures, Empty Set Group, Moving Capital, YADAY, and Arca also participated.

Our view

Portfolio-management software for crypto is a competitive space, yet GenieAI's emphasis on AI-based scenario analysis and no-code strategy deployment could potentially position it at the higher end of the market, where funds already employ data-science teams but need faster infrastructure. Its noncustodial execution model reduces operational risk, and deep integrations with both exchanges and custodians lower switching costs. The main challenges will be sustaining data quality as new venues come online and defending margins if larger infrastructure providers embed similar analytics in their nodes or custody stacks. Still, early engagement by quantitative hedge funds suggests that GenieAI's combination of unified data, predictive models, and trade-routing convenience addresses a tangible pain point for sophisticated allocators.

GLIDER

Founded: 2024

Headquartered: New York, San Francisco

Glider

Overview

Glider, the third Start in Block competition winner, is building a financial orchestration layer for automated, on-chain investment portfolios. The platform emerged from the founders' observation that both novice and experienced traders spend too much time shuffling wallets, bridges, and gas tokens, as well as rebalancing spreadsheets across multiple blockchains. By abstracting those operational details behind a single interface and API, Glider aims to let users express a portfolio view once and have the system execute, rebalance, and lend across networks in the background. The result is positioned as a middle ground between self-directed DeFi and fully custodied robo-advisors: Users keep assets in their wallets, but portfolio maintenance becomes largely hands-off.

Product and technology

The core application combines a no-code portfolio builder with an execution engine that compiles user "intents" into transaction bundles. Allocation tools or template portfolios set target weights; Glider then sources liquidity, manages bridging, and triggers trades across integrated DEXs and lending markets. Liquidity sourcing and cross-chain routing rely on chain-abstraction and intent frameworks, eliminating the need to hold each network's native gas token. A predictive module monitors prices and volatility and can rebalance at intervals ranging from minutes to days. For more sophisticated users, a B2B API exposes the same functionality to wallets, exchanges, and AI agents, enabling white-label portfolio automation. The infrastructure is non-custodial: Assets sit in user-controlled smart wallets that use session keys, while Glider's back end orchestrates calls. Integrated back-testing and collaborative strategy sharing round out the product, allowing users to test ideas on historical data before deploying.

Team

Glider was founded by John Johnson and Brian Huang. Johnson previously led front-end engineering at Ox's Matcha DEX aggregator, giving him direct experience with UX friction in on-chain trading. Huang held engineering and quantitative roles at Anchorage Digital and XTX Markets after graduating from MIT; his background in both custody infrastructure and high-frequency trading informs Glider's focus on execution quality and risk controls. The broader engineering team includes alumni from Coinbase, MetaMask, Cega, and PoolTogether, reflecting a mix of consumer-front-end and protocol-level expertise.

Funding

In April 2025, Glider closed a \$4 million seed round led by Andreessen Horowitz's Crypto Startup Accelerator (CSX) with participation from Coinbase Ventures, Uniswap Labs Ventures, First Commit, Selini Capital, GSR, Generative Ventures, Pivot Global, and MoonPay Ventures. At the same time, the company joined a16z's fourth CSX cohort. Proceeds will expand engineering and partnerships and support additional campaign functionality—such as curated strategy templates

and embedded lending—aimed at broadening the platform from early adopters to mainstream retail investors.

Our view

Glider’s pitch echoes a recurring theme in DeFi of enabling multichain access in one easy-to-use frontend, but the combination of intent-based execution, non-custodial smart wallets, and portfolio-level automation addresses a specific pain felt by users who want diversified exposure without living in spreadsheets. The decision to expose a B2B API as well as a consumer app could help Glider embed itself inside existing wallets and exchanges, turning potential competitors into distribution partners. Key challenges will be maintaining reliable execution across an expanding universe of intent routers and liquidity layers, and convincing advanced traders that Glider’s automated routes match (or beat) the slippage and gas optimization they achieve manually. If Glider can prove that its automation engine delivers competitive net performance while preserving self-custody, it may carve out a defensible niche between single-chain DEX aggregators and fully managed funds.

KRNL Labs

Overview

KRNL Labs is developing a node package manager (npm) for managing smart contract and decentralized application dependencies. Today, most smart-contract logic is confined to the built-in libraries of the chain where an application is deployed; adding new capabilities often means rewriting contracts or standing up custom oracles. KRNL Labs tackles that bottleneck with a registry of off-chain functions—called kernels—that any contract can invoke at run time. By wrapping real-time data look-ups, compliance checks, AI inference, and other routines inside reusable modules, KRNL intends to let developers compose richer applications without inflating on-chain code size or duplicating work.

Product and technology

The centerpiece of the stack is kOS, a modular orchestration layer that connects Web3, Web2, and AI endpoints. Developers publish kernels to the Kernel Registry; each kernel is a WASM-packaged function with on-chain metadata describing inputs, outputs, and pricing. When a smart contract calls a kernel, the request is routed to a KRNL node, executed in the appropriate environment, and the result returned on-chain in the same transaction context. Because kernels execute off-chain, they can tap Web2 APIs or GPU inference without jeopardizing deterministic consensus. Nodes are permissionless: Any Ethereum-compatible remote procedure call node can opt in, earn a share of kernel fees, and thereby expand network capacity. This model delivers asynchronous, cross-chain composability—an application on Arbitrum can call a price-risk kernel running on a Solana validator, for example—while avoiding oracle latency. Based on our discussions with the team, registry smart contracts and node software are open-source, but the matching and fee-routing algorithms are proprietary.



Founded: 2023

Headquartered: London, UK

Team

KRNL Labs was co-founded by Asim Ahmad and Tahir Mahmood. Ahmad spent more than a decade in traditional asset management, including roles at BlackRock, before co-founding the venture firm Eterna Capital in 2018; his experience raising and allocating capital informs KRNL's business model for kernel monetization. Mahmood is a veteran technologist whose career spans distributed-systems engineering and high-performance computing; recent interviews position him as the architect of KRNL's WASM execution pipeline. The broader team of engineers is distributed across Bangkok, London, and Berlin, with contributors from Rust, Golang, and Ethereum-client communities.

Funding

In January 2024, KRNL Labs raised a \$2 million seed round led by YAP Capital, TRGC, and Superscript. Ryze Labs, TPC Ventures, Builder Capital, WAGMi Ventures, STIX, Blockchain Founders Fund, and several angel investors also joined the round. The capital is earmarked for expanding the node operator program, adding developer tooling such as a one-command, command-line interface for kernel deployment, and seeding an incentives fund to bootstrap high-impact kernels in areas such as real-world-asset verification and AI inference.

Our view

KRNL Labs sits at the crossroads of serverless computing and smart-contract development. If successful, the protocol could play the same role for decentralized apps that npm plays for JavaScript: a shared, versioned library of building blocks that speeds iteration and encourages code reuse. Technical execution is nontrivial—secure off-chain execution and economic alignment for node operators remain open questions—but early traction with WASM kernels and the open-source registry suggests the model resonates with developers who want to extend contract functionality without heavyweight oracles. We believe the seed round provides enough runway to prove whether a fee-sharing marketplace can attract both kernel authors and operators; if it does, KRNL Labs could become critical middleware for cross-chain, data-rich applications or an attractive acquisition for a major infrastructure provider seeking to differentiate beyond RPC endpoints.

Liquid Protocol

Overview

Liquid Protocol is building an omnichain, regulatory-compliant infrastructure layer that brings real-world assets (RWAs)—private credit, real estate, LP interests, public-market bonds, equities, and royalties—onto blockchain rails. By letting allocators acquire tokenized slices of traditionally illiquid assets and monitor those positions next to on-chain holdings, the project seeks to simplify portfolio construction across alternative asset classes. The team frames the opportunity around the growth of RWA tokenization and the need for integrated lending and secondary-liquidity tools once those assets are on-chain.



Founded: 2024

Headquartered: London, UK

Product and technology

At the core of Liquid is a Layer-0 protocol that issues RWA-backed tokens, records provenance metadata, and routes cross-chain transfers through Asterizm, an institutional-grade interoperability layer. Assets admitted to the platform are tokenized under a compliance framework the company describes as “regulatory-ready”; each token carries on-chain attestations to underlying legal agreements. Portfolio management takes place in a single dashboard where users can track valuations, rebalance baskets, and trigger secondary trades. A built-in lending market accepts these RWA tokens as collateral, so holders can borrow stablecoins without liquidating exposure—a feature the team pitches as critical for unlocking liquidity in otherwise slow-moving asset classes. Because Asterizm handles messaging across both EVM and non-EVM chains, Liquid can settle loans and secondary trades wherever liquidity is deepest while presenting a unified interface to end users.

Team

The company was co-founded by Hersi Shima (CPO), Denis Polulyakhov (chief business development officer), and Ignat Shapkin (CIO). Shima spent a decade in traditional finance, including vice president roles on BlackRock’s global fixed-income desk and earlier investment-banking experience at Lazard. Polulyakhov is a Techstars London alumnus, co-founded the Asterizm interoperability protocol, and has invested in early-stage Web3 projects through Carbyn Group, a venture studio he founded. Shapkin previously led portfolio management at Edge Capital, a US-based DeFi hedge fund with more than \$150 million under management, and held corporate-banking roles at Citi. The trio is supported by compliance, engineering, and operations veterans spread across London, Berlin, and Bangkok.

Funding

Liquid closed a pre-seed round backed by Funders VC, Optic Capital, Blockchain Founders Fund, V3NTURES, Cicada Capital, and others. The company is currently raising a \$4 million seed round. The capital is allocated to expanding the node network that underpins Asterizm integration, completing a one-command command line interface for asset originators to tokenize deals, and seeding liquidity incentives for the forthcoming lending market.

Our view

RWA tokenization has become a crowded space, yet most platforms stop at asset issuance. Liquid’s blend of portfolio tooling and collateralized lending addresses the problem of what happens to the asset once it is on-chain. Investors still need liquidity, leverage, and secondary price discovery. The decision to anchor interoperability in Asterizm could help Liquid move assets to the chain with the best yield or trading depth without reissuing wrappers, although it also introduces dependency risk on a relatively young interoperability stack. Execution challenges include navigating jurisdiction-specific securities rules and attracting enough high-quality originators to make the marketplace self-sustaining. If Liquid can show that



Founded: 2022

Headquartered: Paris

its end-to-end workflow—from tokenization to loan—cuts time to capital for issuers and delivers yield without sacrificing transparency for buyers, it could carve out a defensible position in the RWA space.

Lobster

Overview

Lobster is a noncustodial DeFi application that automates concentrated-liquidity strategies so users can earn market-making fees without managing ticks or rebalancing ranges themselves. The protocol's starting insight is that the yield available in decentralized exchange (DEX) concentrated-liquidity pools is compelling but operationally intensive; most individual LPs miss out because they lack the tools to monitor volatility, shift ranges, and mitigate impermanent loss. Lobster wraps those tasks in a single-deposit vault interface: A user chooses a token, deposits once, and the system deploys capital across one-sided, pseudo-market-neutral strategies that target up to 10-times higher capital efficiency than passive LP positions.

Product and technology

Under the hood, Lobster runs an execution engine that continuously gathers pool data, estimates volatility, and adjusts liquidity bands. The engine can rebalance positions as often as every block, using delta-hedging tactics when necessary to keep exposure neutral and reduce impermanent loss. Each vault corresponds to a single underlying asset, so depositors avoid the complexity of pairing tokens, while an internal netting module cancels opposite exposures at the portfolio level. Strategies are deployed across multiple EVM chains and protocols—Uniswap v3/v4, Arrakis, and Gamma, with Curve and Maverick on the roadmap—letting the optimizer route capital to whichever venue offers the best fee-to-risk trade-off. We view all vault logic as open-source, although the parameter-tuning models remain proprietary.

Team

Lobster was founded by Alexis Mailley (CEO), Lucas Tissier (COO), and Armand Leullier (CTO). Mailley is an INSA Lyon engineering graduate who spent seven years as a crypto investor and, most recently, consulted for DEX projects on liquidity-growth playbooks. Tissier studied at Télécom Paris, built integration tooling at Byzantine Finance, and now runs day-to-day operations. Leullier, also an INSA Lyon alumnus, previously developed quantitative strategies for a French prop-trading firm and leads Lobster's rebalancing-algorithm research. The founding trio is supported by engineers with Gamma and PoolTogether experience and maintains its headquarters at Station F in Paris.

Funding

Lobster has completed four accelerator programs—most recently, HyperNest's DeFi program. The company previously raised a \$600,000 pre-seed round in early 2024 and is now in the process of raising a \$2 million seed round.

Our view

Automated liquidity-management protocols compete in a crowded segment that includes Gamma, Arrakis, and domain-specific vault builders such as Range and Clever. Lobster’s differentiation lies in its focus on single-asset, pseudo-market-neutral vaults and its willingness to rebalance aggressively, accepting higher gas costs to capture more fees. That design appeals to users who value convenience but still want self-custody. Key risks include sustaining net performance after gas and vault fees and securing enough total value locked to prevent thin-range slippage from outweighing fee gains.

PlayNation

Overview

PlayNation is developing a community layer to bring together a network of social apps that merge commerce, events, chat, and game-like incentives in a single ecosystem. The goal is to help creators, brands, and their fans build communities they own outright instead of renting audience reach from centralized social platforms. By putting relationship data, engagement rewards, and economic flows on-chain, PlayNation aims to let community members share in the value they collectively create while giving brand partners transparent analytics and direct-to-wallet marketing channels.

Product and technology

The stack combines two layers. First is a modular toolset—token-gated chat, event ticketing, quest campaigns, revenue-sharing storefronts, and loyalty dashboards—that creators can enable à la carte. Each module is a self-contained app, but they interoperate through a shared identity graph and a unified points system denominated in the forthcoming \$PLAY token. Second is an application-specific chain that records membership tiers, quest completions, and reward accruals; cross-chain bridges let communities distribute the same rewards on EVM or alternate L2s without fragmenting balances. PlayNation’s early pilots illustrate the model: A token-gated chat for Animoca Brands’ founder summit created more than 5,300 new wallets, an NFT Paris partnership drove 1,800 ticket purchases with 2,250 wallet sign-ups, and an Avalanche art program rewarded creator contributions on-chain.

Team

PlayNation is steered by four founding partners with complementary skill sets. Roy Bernheim, serial entrepreneur and CEO of Decommerce, oversees strategy after scaling the community-led menswear brand TBô to 300,000 customers and brokering a 15-year, \$150 million licensing deal with Procter & Gamble; he holds economics degrees from University College London and the London School of Economics, and a digital-marketing credential from Columbia. Jia Ling Yang, CEO of the Playground product line, brings a decade in creative agencies and Big Tech—leading campaigns for Nike, Converse, YouTube Music, and Facebook—and guest lectures on blockchain at UC Berkeley. Allan Perrottet, COO of Decommerce, is a



Founded: 2024

Headquartered: Switzerland

Swiss Army special-forces veteran turned operator who built TBÖ's community-management platform and tripled its repurchase rate, underpinned by an economics degree from the University of Fribourg. Rounding out the founding team is Saurabh Sachan, CTO of Playground, a 15-year engineering leader who has launched 12 products (three to multimillion-dollar revenue) and founded Venzi.ai, hitting \$500,000 annual recurring revenue within three months. Together, they combine deep expertise in community commerce, brand engagement, and scalable software architecture—skills central to PlayNation's mission of tokenized, creator-owned networks.

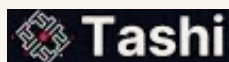
Funding

The company is currently raising a \$1.8 million seed round, and its previous backers include Animoca, Outlier Ventures, GSR, Avalanche, Mysten Labs, and Polygon.

Our view

Platforms that promise community ownership often struggle to balance open participation with effective moderation and spam control. PlayNation's approach, underpinned by on-chain proofs of engagement, offers a potential path to verifiable contribution scoring. Its traction with high-profile events signals demand from brands that want more transparent conversion data than current social channels provide. The critical execution risks are bootstrapping enough creators to generate network effects and navigating token-launch compliance in multiple jurisdictions. If PlayNation successfully demonstrates that gamified, on-chain community tools can lower customer-acquisition costs for brands while paying fans fairly, it could secure a slice of the rapidly growing social commerce category.

Tashi



Founded: 2022

Headquartered: Singapore

Overview

Tashi Protocol is an infrastructure that shifts key elements of online game-state management away from centralized cloud servers and onto a peer-provided node network. Its core idea is that fast-paced multiplayer titles need deterministic consensus at latencies far lower than typical L1 or L2 blockchains can offer. By embedding a purpose-built consensus engine directly in player sessions and anchoring summaries back to public chains when needed, Tashi aims to give studios a side chain they can spin up and tear down for each match while still tapping on-chain economies. The project describes this architecture as a step toward fully on-DAG (directed acyclic graph) gaming, where every in-game action becomes part of a verifiable event graph without harming frame-rate performance.

Product and technology

The centerpiece is the Tashi Consensus Engine (TCE), a Rust implementation that bundles player inputs into events, assembles them into a DAG, and reaches finality through virtual voting; because voting is local, throughput exceeds one million transactions per second in benchmark tests while CPU and memory usage stay low. Developers access the engine via Dynamite, a Unity-first SDK that will support the

Unreal and Godot gaming engines next; a few API calls replace traditional net-code with mesh networking that is invisible to end users.

Underneath, a decentralized physical infrastructure network layer of resource nodes (relay, matchmaking, wallet signing) and orchestration nodes (job queuing, fee routing) earns the forthcoming network token, creating economic incentives to supply bandwidth and compute. Cross-chain modules let games escrow assets and settle outcomes on EVM or alternative L2s without exposing players to gas or key-management friction. Core contracts, node software, and SDK samples are open-source; adaptive parameter-tuning and matchmaking heuristics remain proprietary.

Team

CEO Amar Bedi spent a decade in finance and consulting—including stints in investment banking and a managing-director role at BridgePort—before shifting to Web3 gaming; recent interviews emphasize his focus on seamless user experiences that hide blockchain complexity. CTO Ken Anderson is a distributed-systems veteran and former developer advocate at Hedera Hashgraph; he designed the first production version of the Tashi Consensus Engine and frequently speaks on asynchronous Byzantine fault tolerance algorithms for gaming workloads. Chief Business Officer Jay McCarthy brings VC and climate finance experience and now leads partnerships with studios and node-operator networks.

Funding

In 2023, Tashi raised an undisclosed seed round from Mochax and angel investors and is currently raising a \$2 million seed round.

Our view

Tashi attacks an addressable cost center—multiplayer server spend—that even the largest Web2 studios would like to decrease. The company's reward loop is conceptually attractive to hardware owners chasing graphics processing unit yield. The commercial hurdle is twofold: convincing AAA studios to entrust competitive integrity to peer devices and ensuring enough geographically proximate resource nodes to hit sub-50-millisecond round-trip times in all regions. Competitors such as Beamable, Portal, or Render's upcoming edge network tackle similar economics without the complexity of on-DAG consensus. If TCE can demonstrate equal or better cheat resistance with materially lower costs, Tashi could become an Unreal Engine for serverless multiplayer games.